price) for their produce, anger quickly built up. Even sweeteners like a 10 per cent annual increment in the annuity failed to seduce the farmer lobby. CM Mann's protestations that the LPP was "voluntary, this is not land acquisition...the farmer remains the owner, trust us" didn't go too far either.

BEGINNING OF THE END

On July 31, Ludhiana—a cornerstone of Punjab's industry and central to the 'land pooling' blueprint—woke up to 500 tractors roaring at the gates of the local administration. Farmer leader Harinder Singh Lakhowal of the Bharatiya Kisan Union (Lakhowal) thundered: "This isn't land pooling, it's backdoor acquisition. And we'll stop it, just like we did the farm laws." By then, the courts were also involved. On August 7, the Punjab and Haryana High Court ordered an interim stay on the policy after flagging the lack of social/ environmental impact assessments and the absence of concrete rehabilitation measures. It also expressed reservations against the diverting of Punjab's fertile agricultural land, citing the Land Acquisition Act, 2013.

Four days later, the Mann government caved in and rolled back the LPP. All related actions—letters of intent (LoIs), registrations, planning exercises—stood nullified. Sources say the realisation dawned, among the powers that be, that the policy may not stand up to the court's scrutiny. But the main cause for the retreat was the protests flaring up statewide by the farming community, cutting across class and ideological barriers—almost a replay of the 2020/21 action that had forced the Centre to repeal the farm laws. With the Opposition also up in arms and the AAP government losing the narrative, Mann had no other choice. But though he may have curtailed the fallout, there was no denying the dent to the government's image.



MESSAGE DELETED CM Mann at a presser in Amritsar in late July

MANN, WHO IS FROM THE DOMINANT JAT SIKH COMMUNITY, HAD WON WITH THEIR BACKING IN 2022. BACKING OFF ON LPP WAS ALSO KEEPING THE RURAL VOTER IN MIND

Opposition leaders, such as BJP state vice-president Subhash Sharma, were quick to highlight the "core weaknesses" of the policy—lack of transparency and inadequate social safety provisions. For Mann, whose leadership persona was built on rural outreach, it became a big blow to his credibility, especially among farmers.

A DISILLUSIONED LOT

In the 2022 assembly election, the Jat Sikh community had helped propel AAP to 92 of the total 117 seats. Mann, a Jat Sikh himself, had captivated rural voters with promises of social justice, MSP protection for their produce and dignified governance. Jat Sikhs in Punjab are about 18 per cent of the population, but the 2015 agriculture census suggests that they own about 94 per cent of the state's farmland. As a result, they have an outsized influence on any decision that impacts agriculture in Punjab. In recent years, they have been restive on a variety of issues: the drift in Akali politics, the lack of resolution in the 2015 sacrilege cases, the central farm laws and the impasse on diversification in the MSP product base.

The situation had been simmering since mid-March when the Mann government took action against the agitating farmers jamming the national highway at the Shambhu and Khanauri state border points with Haryana for the past year, demanding a legal framework for MSP procurement. The Haryana government had blocked them, stopping their progress to Delhi like during the 2020/21 the farm law